Lesson 5 — The Two O'Clock Class

Part 1 of 12: Passage — The Two O'Clock Class

Level: A2+ → B1 (fifth step)

About 20 minutes · this part carries a sheet and audio

> How to do the listening. The same rule as every lesson so far: the student listens twice with no text, then reads. Audio files: `01-passage.mp3` first, then the other parts in order. Part `05-ing-and-been.mp3` is new — the -ing ending and the weak been.

1.1 Before listening (2 minutes, Arabic is fine here)

1. What have you been learning for a long time?
2. Is there something you do at the same time every week?
3. Who taught you to use a computer, and how?

1.4 Now read the passage

Passage: The Two O'Clock Class (481 words)

Rana is twenty-six, and for the last eighteen months she has been teaching a free computer class for children. It happens in one room above her father's shop, and it starts at two o'clock every Saturday.

[A] She is not a teacher. She studied accounting, and she works in an office four days a week. But three years ago she watched a boy in the market trying to fill in a form on a borrowed phone, typing with one finger, and she could not stop thinking about it.

The class has eleven children in it now. Most of them are beginners. They have been learning the same small things, again and again: how to hold a mouse, how to click once and not twice, where the letters are on the keyboard, how to save a file before the power goes.

[B] The electricity comes for about six hours a day, and nobody knows which six. So Rana keeps a timetable on the wall, and ignores it when she has to. The two laptops in the room are old. One of them has a battery that lasts forty minutes; the other has none at all, and it stops the moment the power stops.

Her brother has been repairing those two laptops since the class began. He works in a phone shop six days a week, and he comes here on the seventh. He is patient in a way that Rana says she is not. He has installed the same program four times on the same machine, because a child deleted it four times, and he has never once sounded angry about it.

[C] The children are getting faster. Six months ago most of them typed with one finger, like the boy in the market. Now four of them type without looking down, and one girl, who is nine, has been teaching her own mother in the evenings. Two of them have been coming since the first Saturday and have not missed one.

Rana has been keeping a list since the first Saturday. It has one line for each child: what they can do, and what they are still finding hard. She has not shown it to anyone. It is four pages long now.

[D] People ask her how long she will go on with it. She says she does not know, and that it is not really the right question. The right question, she says, is what a child can do at the end of a year that she could not do at the beginning. For that, the list on her desk already has an answer.

She has been doing this for eighteen months, and she has never asked anyone for money. In that time the class has lost four children and gained seven. The room still has two old laptops. The electricity still comes for six hours a day, and still nobody knows which six.

1.5 Read aloud

Read the passage aloud once and record it. This is the longest passage so far: see whether you can keep going to the end without stopping.